A RAJPUT IN THE SNOW

Mid-winter in Kashmir was the season of long nights, ice flurries, and impenetrable high passes. It was a time when men sheltered in the shadows of the great mountains and dreamt of spring. So when Akbar's army of 5,000 specially-equipped war horses commanded by Raja Bhagwant Das and Shah Quli Mehram marched from Attock along the Pakhli Route through the ravine of Baramullah in December 1585, the forces of the Sultan of Kashmir, Yusuf Shah Chak, were caught unawares. Even so, skirmishing between the two armies was vicious, made even more brutal by the slicing sleet and the lack of provisions. The Kashmir sultan began to push the Mughal army back but he didn't press home his advantage. This was because the years of diplomacy by the Mughals, in which the Kashmir sultan's supremacy had been steadily undermined and dissidents supported, meant that Yusuf Shah Chak's grip on power had been eroded and he was willing to make peace as soon as he received a letter from the Rajput general ominously warning that 'although this time the royal army was defeated, next time a force thousand times larger than this would be dispatched (against you) and it would be difficult for you to save your life. Therefore,' continued Bhagwant Das, 'I suggest to you that it is better for you to proceed with me to the presence of Emperor Akbar.' The striking of coins and the reciting of the khutba would continue in Akbar's name, agreed Yusuf Shah, and he also promised to bring his son, Yakub Shah, to Akbar. It was agreed that Yusuf Shah needed only to accompany Bhagwant Das to pay obeisance before the Mughal Padshah before returning to Kashmir.

However, when the Mughal army returned to the imperial court at Attock, Akbar was in no mood for conciliation and disapproved of the treaty which Bhagwant Das had negotiated on his own. He had Yusuf Shah arrested, discomfitting his Rajput general who had brought the Kashmir sultan into Hindustan upon his honour. Bhagwant Das was so mortified by what he perceived as a slur that when Akbar appointed him Governor to Kabul a few months later, he laid down certain conditions regarding the extent of his authority before he would agree to take up office. This,